

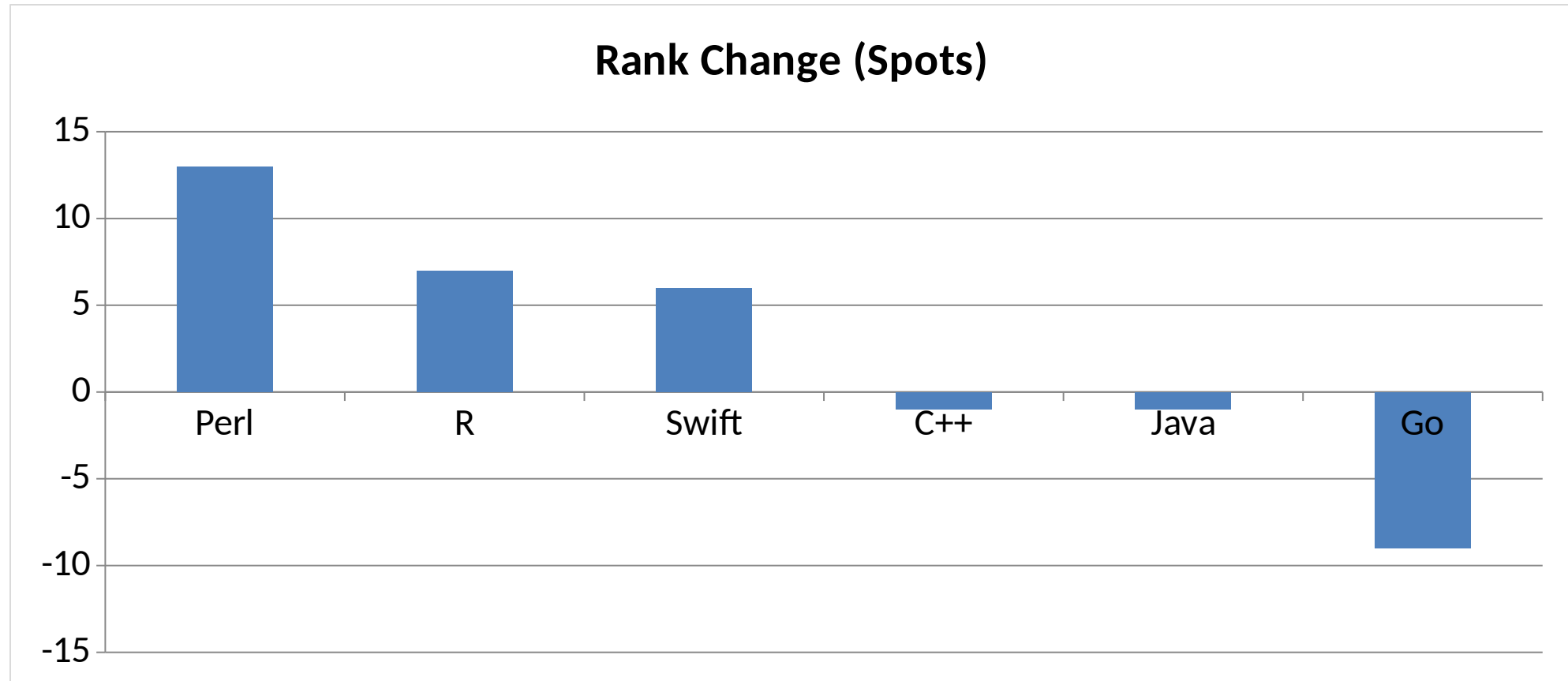
TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

- **TIOBE Programming Community Index Methodology**
 - What it measures: The popularity of programming languages based on the number of skilled engineers worldwide, courses, and third-party vendors.
 - Data Sources: Search-engine hit counts across Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20+ other sites.
 - What it DOES NOT measure: The index does not measure which language is the "best" or which has the most lines of code written.
 - Key takeaway: It is a metric of demand and discussion volume on the public internet.

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Rank (Mar 2026)	Rank (Mar 2025)	Programming Language	Rating	YoY Change
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	26	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%

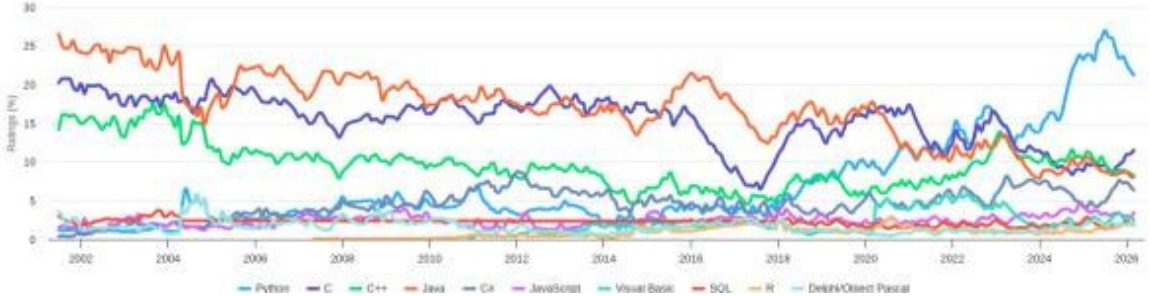
Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 -- The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026



Notable Gainers: Perl (24th to 11th) | R (16th to 9th) | Swift (26th to 20th)
Notable Losers: Go (7th to 16th) | C++ (2nd to 3rd) | Java (3rd to 4th)

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Programming Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	-	-
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	-	-
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	-	-	-
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	-	-
Visual Basic	7	6	11	-	-	-	-	-	-
Delphi/Object Pascal	8	185	12	12	9	-	-	-	-
SQL	9	10	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
Go	10	11	60	16	-	-	-	-	-
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2
(Visual) Basic	-	-	-	6	6	4	3	3	4



Historical Patterns (2002–2026 & Four-Decade Snapshot):

- Python's Rise: Unranked before 1991, entered top 30 in 2001, reached #1 post-2018.
- Java's Decline & C's Resilience: Java dominated 2005-2018 but fell under 8%. C is the ONLY language in the top 2 across all nine points (1986-2026).
- Legacy Shifts: Lisp dropped from #2 (1986) to #26. Ada from #3 to #14.

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times -- More Than Any Other Language

Year	Winner
2025	C#
2024	Python
2023	C#
2022	C++
2021	Python
2020	Python
2019	C
2018	Python
2017	C
2016	Go
2015	Java
2014	JavaScript
2013	Transact-SQL
2012	Objective-C
2011	Objective-C
2010	Python
2009	Go
2008	C
2007	Python
2006	Ruby
2005	Java
2004	PHP
2003	C++

Awarded to the language with the largest gain in ratings:

- Python holds the record with 6 wins (2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024).
- C# took the title in both 2023 and 2025, driven by the .NET ecosystem.
- Go won in 2016, a sharp contrast to its recent decline in rankings.
- Note: The 2017 winner is not available in the source data.

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

- **Actionable Implications for Technology Decisions:**
 - Concentration Risk: Python, C, C++, and Java account for 48.97% of the total TIOBE ratings. The programming landscape remains highly concentrated.
 - Python's Momentum Shift: While still #1 at 21.25%, its -2.59% YoY decline is the largest among the top 5, signaling potential stabilization or saturation.
 - C's Resurgence: Gaining +2.02 points and climbing to #2 underscores the enduring demand for performance and systems-level control.
 - Legacy Ecosystem Value: The unexpected rise of Perl, R, and Fortran shows that entrenched communities (data analysis, scientific computing, infrastructure) still hold significant weight.
 - Systems Programming Churn: Go's sharp drop (-1.49%) alongside Rust's steady presence suggests shifting preferences in modern systems programming.